



Figure 5: Customising the workspace



Figure 6: Options for customisation



Figure 7: Dashboard shows two apps running

Maemo gives you is that when a menu pops out, the rest of the desktop screen becomes blurred. You simply tap on the blurred portion of the screen (that is, anywhere outside the menu) to get back to the desktop. Once the icons/widgets are on screen you can move them around with your finger, and place them at the right positions.

As you can see in Figure 5, all these widgets/shortcuts also have an X icon on their top-right edge to close/delete them, and an additional config icon on their bottom-left edge (if the item needs any further configuration). For example, you'll need to enter your authentication details into the Twitter/Facebook widgets to have it display the updates. When you're satisfied with their placements, tap the *Done* button on the top right portion of the screen.

The most interesting part of the desktop is perhaps the dashboard. Take a look at Figure 1 and 2 again. The blue icon on the extreme top-left corner of the screen is to access the dashboard. However, the icons are different in both the figures. Why?

In Figure 1, where it shows two overlapping blue rectangles (windows), it indicates that there are applications running in the background. Tap on it to access these. Figure 7 shows how things are arranged when only two apps are open, while Figure 8 shows 13 apps open—well, multitasking is a piece of cake on Maemo as you can see.

The dashboard can fit up to 12 apps. If you open more apps, you'll have to scroll using your finger.

In Figures 2, you can see the dashboard icon replaced by an icon with a set of six small blue rectangles. Tap it to access the application menu (Figure 9). [To get back to the desktop, tap an empty section of the screen.] In Figure 2, I wasn't running any application in the background, and hence it showed the app menu instead of the dashboard icon.

As you can see in the application menu in Figure 9, the list consists of typical things you get in any phone. However, 'More...' (the last icon on the list) is where the rest of the apps go. Tap and view the apps—Figure 10.

By default, there are about a dozen apps here—the screenshot shows a lot more because I'd already installed a lot of apps before I sat down to write about them. Out of the box, N900 comes with a few basic apps like a note-taking application, a PDF reader, RSS reader, a sketching app (so you can use N900 as a digital pen), a few games, an X terminal (yay!), file manager and application manager. Using this App Manager you can install more apps, configure repositories, etc. Yes, it's the *apt-get* magic. Did I tell you, Maemo is based on Debian? :-)

Before I get into the details, let me again get back to the desktop where we have the system tray that sits next to the dashboard icon. It shows you the clock, the cellphone network strength, battery indicator, the Wi-Fi radar if you're connected to an access point, the IM status, GPS, etc—basically, things that go into



Figure 8: Dashboard shows 13 apps running



Figure 9: Applications menu



Figure 10: 'More...' apps menu



Figure 11: System tray details

a typical desktop system tray. Tap it to access detailed statuses or configure things (Figure 11).

Note that, I'm giving you a demonstration using a fully-setup device. You'll need to set up a few things (even install a few apps from third-party repos) before getting started, obviously.